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UNIVERSITÀ DEGLI STUDI DI NAPOLI “L’ORIENTALE”
DIPARTIMENTO ASIA, AFRICA E MEDITERRANEO

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IRANIAN STUDIES
IN HONOUR OF ADRIANO V. ROSSI

PART TWO

Edited by
SABIR BADALKHAN, GIAN PIETRO BASELLO and MATTEO DE CHIARA



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Adriano V. Rossi all'inizio degli anni 2000.

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MARCO MANCINI
Roma

Middle-Persian Morphology and Old Persian Masks: Some Reflections on “Proto-Middle Persian”¹

τοὶ δ' ἀνὰ γᾶν Ἀσίαν δὴν
οὐκέτι περσονομοῦνται,
οὐδ' ἔτι δασμοφοροῦσιν
δεσποσύνοισιν ἀνάγκαις,
οὐδ' ἐς γᾶν προπίτνοντες
ἄζονται: βασιλεία
γὰρ διόλωλεν ἰσχύς.
(Aeschylus, *Persae*, vv. 584-590)

1. In his recent *Forschungsbericht* devoted to Old Persian (henceforth OP) language and script, Adriano Rossi has correctly emphasized the relevance of Prods Skjærvø's review of the *Beiträge zu altpersischen Inschriften* (Skjærvø 1999), which were published by Rüdiger Schmitt two decades ago (Schmitt 1999): “Skjærvø criticizes – Rossi says – the inference of the linguistic evolution of OP from (pseudo)historical extra-linguistic notions” (Rossi 2017: 361).² The reference is to the sharply-debated case of *spätachaimenidische*

¹ I wish to express my profound gratitude to my Colleagues Maria Carmela Benevenuto, Claudia Ciancaglini, Paolo Milizia and Giancarlo Schirru for their valuable comments, suggestions and discussions. Adriano Rossi, once again, with his usual and warm friendship, generously read a first version of this paper which I presented at the Meeting on “Languages and Cultures in Contact in the Ancient Mediterranean” (Verona, February the 21st, 2019). The entire responsibility of this article is obviously the author's.

² Similar observations were already put forward in Rossi 2008: 99-100, where, in addition to Skjærvø 1999, a quotation from Skjærvø 2007 was also reported. For a misprint in Rossi 2017: 361, the former was dropped and only the latter, albeit less meaningful, occurs. Actually, Skjærvø 2007: 858, simply repeated his previous advice: “the lateness of the language of the inscriptions in the history of Old Persian warns against forcing phonetic and grammatical forms too much into an Old Iranian mold; instead one should consider Old Persian as intermediate between the Old Iranian and the Middle Iranian language types”.

Altpersische, namely a scientific label indicating the OP variety of the Late Achaemenid monuments in cuneiform script, dating back to the 5th-4th centuries B.C.

Skjærvø claimed that Schmitt provided a very questionable interpretation of the Late Achaemenid linguistic data. Firstly, in Skjærvø's opinion, Rüdiger Schmitt built up his phonological descriptions by means of a "neogrammarian" approach, both – so to speak – "*stammbäumlich*" and "*lautgesetzlich*", whereas the reconstructions were "as close as possible to those restored for proto-Iranian on the basis of comparison with Old Indic" (Skjærvø 1999: 158b). This paradigm seems to completely ignore the criticism of many Iranologists "who have emphasized that Old Persian should also be seen in light of Middle Persian developments" (Skjærvø 1999: 158b). Secondly, because in the OP inscriptions engraved from Artaxerxes I's times onwards (465-424 B.C.) "the scribes [...] obviously spoke a new stage of language, it is [...] advisable to take Middle Persian into consideration to a larger extent than Schmitt does" (Skjærvø 1999: 158b). Skjærvø points out, therefore, that no "moral condemnation" can be admitted, when we attempt to describe the late OP, which cannot absolutely be considered as an "ungrammatical", "linguistically deviant", or "barbaric" variety. So, to conclude with Skjærvø's own words: "surely, the description of languages as 'degenerate' or 'barbaric' has no place in modern linguistic literature" (Skjærvø 1999: 159a).

To put it in another way, the Persian variety of these late cuneiform inscriptions should be read, described and thoroughly interpreted as a mere manifestation of 'Proto-Middle Persian' (henceforth PMP),³ as a consistent

³ In his seminal review, Skjærvø casts doubt on the appropriate metalinguistic label to term the linguistic stage behind (or below) the late cuneiform inscriptions: "the stage of Persian intermediate between Old and Middle Persian, which must therefore be termed post-Old Persian or pre-Middle Persian for lack of an adjective between 'Old' and 'Middle'. The important thing is to realize that it is neither Old nor Middle Persian" (Skjærvø 1999: 159a). However, in Skjærvø 2007: 59 and, more decisively, in Skjærvø 2007: 47-48 (where the scholar underlines that "one should consider Old Persian as suspended, as it were, between the Old Iranian and the Middle Iranian language types"), his proposal is to term this stage "*Proto-Middle Persian*", a label which seems to adequately fit a variety, whose norms were still referring graphically and culturally to the Achaemenid cuneiform: a language, however, that was concretely shifting to the Middle Persian phase (see also Skjærvø 2016: 140: "the inscriptions from Artaxerxes II on are written in what is clearly a post-OPers. stage of the language. Those from Artaxerxes I and Darius II

état de langue, and should not be merely stigmatized as an abnormal usage of the Court language spoken during Darius and Xerxes’ era.⁴

are less clear; they are written in a late-OPers. form”). Notice that PMP is a ‘*proto*’-language and not a ‘*pre*’-language, for we are firmly convinced that this stage ought not be somehow reconstructed, but it is clearly evidenced by the late Achaemenid inscriptions. Back’s label *das Spätpersische* (see Back 1978: 4) was coined on the basis of the inscriptional Middle Persian orthography as an alleged “Bindeglied zwischen dem Altpersischen der Achämenideninschriften und dem tatsächlichen Mittelpersisch des 3. Jh. n.”. A severe criticism by the great majority of Iranian scholars considers this glottonym unacceptable: cf. Schmitt 1980: 75 (“da diese postulierte Zwischenstufe aber nicht mehr in altiranische Zeit gehört, erscheint es problematisch, ob dieser Terminus [viz. *das Spätpersische*] glücklich gewählt wurde”), Gignoux 1984: 269, Huyse 2003: 26–27; and also see Sundermann 1989b: 139. All these authors suggest the label ‘Proto-Middle Persian’ with regard to the postulated ‘Early Middle Persian’ reconstructed by comparing the Middle Iranian forms: thus, Sims-Williams uses “the term ‘Early MP’ to refer to a (postulated) stage at which the declension of *-a-* stems had been simplified to: dir. sing. and pl. *-Ø*, obl. sing *-ē*, obl. pl. *-ān*” (Sims-Williams 1981: 169, fn 20; Back does not believe that a diptotic inflectional system existed at this stage, cf. Back 1978: 34–39). We will argue in this paper that the late cuneiform inscriptions already exhibit this diptotic stage of the inflectional morphology. Therefore, ‘Early Middle Persian’ cannot be adopted here.

⁴ As Rossi pointed out in a groundbreaking essay several years ago, the linguistic repertoire of the Achaemenid Empire is far from being perfectly outlined. Furthermore, account must be taken of the fact that a wide range of oral varieties, mainly not standardized and without any ongoing *Ausbau*-process, were commonly practised and interfered throughout the Iranian territories: “il fatto che le trasposizioni tra codici avvengano tra varietà non standardizzate, reinterpretate ad ogni atto comunicativo negli idioletti dei parlanti che spesso le hanno acquisite in età adulta e le controllano in modo approssimativo, in situazioni comunicative in cui la tematica predetermina la scelta di registri e tecnoletti, crea le circostanze perché gli atti comunicativi fissati nei testi riflettano da un lato la massima quantità possibile di varietà areale e sociale, dall’altro un certo carattere ‘prefabbricato’, artificiale” (Rossi 1981: 190–191). Thus, we might say, each epigraphic text has its own history and ought to be described by means of a fairly complex set of diachronic, diatopic, diastratic and diaphasic features. Hence, with regard to the divergent sections which were typical of the late cuneiform inscriptions (see below the reference to the “free” and “formulaic” portions), Rossi’s multi-dimensionally layered analysis is still the most convincing sociolinguistic tool we possess when dealing with OP texts. Consequently, the idea that the OP inscriptions coherently reflected an archaic and artificial language must be deeply questioned, despite numerous authoritative opinions, cf. Schmitt 1989: 57 (“reiner Rep-

2. These statements, albeit obvious, highlight a very relevant issue in literature, both from a scientific and a methodological perspective. Admittedly, most of these critical observations concerning Schmitt's work are ungenerous. Actually, in his essay, Schmitt systematically treated many grammatical points recovered in the PMP monuments, such as, e.g., the noun inflectional morphology (see Schmitt 1999: 65-66 and 94-100) or the synthetical verb forms of the ancient aspectual and temporal stems (imperfect, aorist, and participle constructions, see Schmitt 1999: 75-77 and 100-104). However, it is an irrefutable fact that the bulk of the articles devoted to inspect the late Achaemenid language have been limited to offering sheer definitions, which are far from being convincing: the inscriptions were "full of mistakes", "syntactically incoherent", and so forth. According to some scholars, the "errors" in these inscriptions were due to the imper-

räsentationssprache des Königtums"), Schmitt 1993: 78-79 (where "eine mit dialektfremden und archaischen Wörtern und Formen durchsetzte, in mannigfacher Hinsicht 'Kunstsprache'" on one side and "die altpersische Umgangssprache" reflected in the *Nebenüberlieferungen* on the other side are accurately distinguished), Lecoq 1997: 49-50 ("c'est une langue mixte, un mélange volontaire de vieux perse, de mède [...] donc une langue artificielle qui n'a jamais eu d'usage parlé"), Schmitt 2000: 30-31, Schmitt 2004: 717 ("rather artificial idiom, peppered with dialectal and archaic words, unlike any dialect actually spoken [...] restricted to Royal usage"), Stolper 2005: 19 ("an artificial idiom, drawing forms from several Iranian dialects, both contemporary and old, and using a grammar that was already archaic when the inscriptions were made"), Tavernier 2013: 639 ("rather artificial, i.e. it did not reflect the spoken language very well"), Maggi & Orsatti 2018: 10 ("a formal language with many loanwords and an archaizing character"). This notwithstanding, a study of the highly formulaic parts of the inscriptions as well as of the "rhetoric" tools consciously employed by the royal chanceries is recommended, see the repertoire of Schmitt 2016. The recent discovery of an OP cuneiform clay tablet from Persepolis has fortunately reopened the discussion about the pragmatic functions of the Achaemenid script: see Stolper & Tavernier 2007 and Tavernier 2013: 651. If OP is treated as an artificial language, a correct evaluation of its inner variation is hardly conceivable, see Rossi's critical approach to Lecoq's theory in Rossi 1981: 183-186. In a rigidly close-knit network (see Milroy & Milroy 1985: 359-364), as far as we reconstruct it with regard to the Achaemenid aristocracy, it seems likely to assume a single variety supported by a "norm-enforcement mechanism" (Milroy & Milroy 1985: 359). The late traces of variation in the cuneiform inscriptions at issue hint at a diachronic development, rather than simply the intrusion of informal markers.

fect knowledge of the Court language by foreigner scribes with a different mother-tongue.⁵

In our opinion, this approach seems unacceptable and the linguistic analysis cannot be atomistically conducted on the grounds of single points without any connection each other.

Actually, any assumption on the late Achaemenid language is all the more relevant, because it concerns a crucial period from a strictly typological point of view. Meillet already described this typology with his well-known lucidity in his booklet on the *Méthode comparative en linguistique historique*:

entre le perse achéménide et le pehlvi sassanide, il y a une différence de développement aussi grande que celle qui sépare le latin ancien du roman. Entre les deux dates, la langue a changé de caractère. Comme sur le domaine latine, l'essentiel du changement s'est passé hors de la vue de l'historien. Le linguiste dispose de deux états de langue profondément distincts l'un de l'autre; pour faire une histoire, il lui faut restituer l'entre-deux. La comparaison des diverses parlers

⁵ See for instance Meillet & Benveniste 1931: 24 (“l’embarras de rédacteurs perses ignorants ou même étrangers”), 26 (“un fonctionnaire qui ne savait pas le perse, qui le comprenait à demi sans en connaître la grammaire et qui calquait gauchement des modèles d’inscriptions qu’il avait sous les yeux”), Schaefer 1931: 640 (“sie [viz. die Inschriften] könnten gar nicht von Schreibern persischer Nationalität verfasst worden sein”). Schmitt also refers to this hypothesis, with regard to the confusion between <š> and <c> in A²Sa 3 (<x-š-y-a-r-c-h-y-a> instead of <x-š-y-a-r-š-h-y-a>): “da diese Variation š ~ c am deutlichsten in dem vorliegenden Königsnamen auszumachen ist und sich auf diese eine Inschrift beschränkt, ist hier kaum mit einem Phänomen allgemeinerer Art, also mit einer für das Spätaltpersische typischen sprachlichen Veränderung, sondern viel eher mit einem individuellen Fehler zu rechnen. Für diesen darf als entscheidend am ehesten Fremdeinfluß irgendwelcher Art, etwa eines Schreibers mit nicht-persischer, vielleicht aramäischer Muttersprache angenommen werde” (Schmitt 1999: 71, see also 114). On the contrary, even though a fake inscription was concerned, namely A¹I, see *infra*, Herzfeld correctly pointed to a MP language below the apparent OP forms: “wenn man aber die inschrift als ältestes mittelpersisch ansieht, und in h y a, der relativischen i d ā f a, mit vi θ i y ā zusammen den altertümlichsten ausdruck – noch ohne correctur durch enklit. pron. poss. – für mp. ē. š. visrāδ [sic] erblickt, so ergibt sich, sprachlich richtig: ‘Artaxerxes etc. etc. für dessen palast diese silberschüssel gemacht ist’. In ihrer syntax ist die inschrift mittelpersisch gedacht. Auch die flexion war schon mittelpersisch, nur durch falsch archaisierende endungen verkleidet, wie bei Artaxerxes II und III” (Herzfeld 1938: 46).

iraniens modernes aide à faire cette restitution; mais ne elle fournit que des directions, non des témoignages positifs (Meillet 1925: 10).

This “entre-deux” is a kind of “dark ages in the history of Iran” (Callieri & Askari Chaverdi 2013: 690), a period that connects the latest stage of Achaemenid epigraphy on one side to the earliest epigraphic texts of the Sassanian era on the other. Except for some monetary artefacts in Aramaic characters from which only scarce onomastic information can be obtained, the lapse of time from the end of the 4th century B.C. to the beginning of the 3rd century A.D. remains a completely unmarked territory, namely a period with very few of Meillet’s “positive testimonies”.⁶ Therefore, our possibilities of reconstructing the diachronic processes that led OP to develop into Middle Persian (henceforth MP) in a reliable way are greatly reduced. This represents an especially serious challenge, because the Western varieties of the Iranian linguistic domain faced an abrupt typological acceleration, during these centuries of documentary “blackout”.

This all leads us, therefore, to conclude that any attempt to trace back to the morpho-phonological development of Western Iranian languages clashes with huge obstacles, given that the concept of MP itself is actually based “wie oft bei den Periodisierung geschieht, statt auf innersprachlichen Verhältnissen, auf Mängel in seinen Belege”, as Adriano Rossi correctly observed (Rossi 1987: 207).

3. Within this overall picture, the issue of the apparently-“deviant” linguistic usages behind the late cuneiform inscriptions plays, in our opinion, a pivotal role. However, both the graphemic and linguistic data need to be read and interpreted by means of a new systemic approach, which aims to

⁶ On this topic, with regard mainly to the Persian materials, see Henning 1958: 24-25, Frye 1984: 158-160, Wiesehöfer 1994: 89-96, Sellwood 2006: 299-311 (numismatics), Sundermann 1989b: 139 (“auf die 3. Jh. n. Chr. vorangehende frühmittelpersische Sprachphase werfen deren einzige Zeugnisse, die seit dem 3. Jh. v. Chr. geprägten und vielleicht seit dem 2. Jh. v. Chr. mittelpersisch zu lesenden Münzen der Persis, kein Licht”). Besides the coinage of the Persis’ dynasties, a Middle-Persian inscription on a silver cup is the single remarkable text of this epoch, cf. Skjærvø 1997. These documents provide only a partial information from a linguistic point of view, because of the large amount of Aramaic heterograms. Many Parthian materials are collected in Weber’s “Parthische Texte” in Hackl & Jacobs & Weber 2010: 492-588, where the pahlavik inscriptions of the Sasanian era are also edited. At a first glance, very few linguistic data, except the onomastic ones, can be detected from these texts, which still employ massively Aramaic heterograms.

retrace the overall PMP *état de langue* and not the single “mistakes” or “barbarisms” found in this or that inscription.

We quote just one crucial example, in order to clarify our position. Let us take into account the OP inflectional morphology in these late inscriptions.

On one hand, we are able to list several forms written with an <-a-m> that surfaces as a “passe-partout” case-marker, in Schmitt’s opinion (Schmitt 1999: 95 and 114), redundantly attached to the OP stem: see <b-u-m-a-m> instead of the expected <b-u-mⁱ-i-m> in A³Pa (i.e. the A³Pa^a version) 2, <a-s-m-a-n-a-m> instead of the expected <a-s-m-a-n-m> in A³Pa 3, <p-r-d-y-d-a-m> in A²Sd^{a,d} 3, <i-m-a-m> instead of the expected <i-m> in A²Sc 4, A²Sd 3.

On the other hand, we note in several inscriptions the fossilization of several “zero”-case forms, which Schmitt inappropriately termed “nominative for genitive” or “nominative for locative” (Schmitt 1999: 114-116):⁷ see respectively <d-a-r-y-v-u-š XŠ-h-y-a> in A²Sb, <a-r-t-x-š-ç-a x-š-a-y-θ-i-y p-u-ç> in A³Pa 12-13; <p-a-r-s-a> in AsH 3 instead of the expected <p-a-r-s-i-y> (to be read /pārs/, with a final <a>, that functioned here as a purely graphic relic, descending from an ancient *mater lectionis* according to Meillet, Hinz and Kuryłowicz’s proposals who argued – as would we – for an Aramaic matrix of the OP cuneiform script).⁸ See also words such as <a-p-d-

⁷ In another interesting passage of his *Beiträge* Rüdiger Schmitt seems to prefer an overall phonological explanation of the forms written without the expected final <m>: “da diese Formen auf */-am/, das graphisch unbezeichnet bleibt, außer dieser lautlichen keine weitere Gemeinsamkeit aufweisen und ganz unterschiedlichen Wortklassen angehören, mögen sie eine gemeinsame Erklärung dergestalt finden, daß, wenn man nicht wie schon für einige Formen einer Xerxes-Inschrift (XPh46 t^u-u-v statt t^u-u-v-m /tuvam/ ‘du’ und XPh 47 a-p-r statt a-p-r-m /aparam/, ‘später’) mit einer Nachlässigkeit des Schreibers rechnet, entweder der auslautende Nasal oder die ganze Endsilbe mit Ausnahme ihres Anlauts) geschwunden ist, so wie die sprachliche Weiterentwicklung zum Mittelpersischen es voraussetzt” (Schmitt 1999: 73).

⁸ For the thorny question of final spellings in OP cuneiform script, see Mancini 1992a. In the light of further reflection, I am now convinced that the neutralization of phonemic oppositions in final syllables (see Kuryłowicz 1975: 500) concerned all the ancient pre-pausal vowels: thus, <i-y>, <-u-v> and <a> were spellings for the neutralized bundle of quantitative oppositions /i/~i/, /ü/~ü/ and /ā/~ā/ (including /ā/ from Anc. Ir. /āC/, such as in the athematic aorist <a-d-a> OP *adā* < Anc. Ir. **adāt*, ‘he made’), whilst, according to Diakonoff 1970: 106 fn. 23,

a-n> (Schmitt 1999: 72-74), <a-b-y-p-r>, <a-n-h-t> in A²Sa 4-5, and the preterites <a-k^u-u-n-v-a-m> (A²Sd^b 3), <a-k^u-u-n-a> (A²Sa 6, A²Ha 7) <[a-k^u-u-n]-a-m> (A²Ha 5), <a-k^u-u-n-i-y> (A²Sa 5), <a-k^u-v-n-š-a-š> (A²Sd^c 3)⁹ and <n-s-t-a-y> (A²Sa).¹⁰

A particularly intriguing example is given by the forms <a-p-n-y-a-k-m> and <n-y-k-m> in A²Sa 4-5. According to Schmitt's phonological transcription, these spellings correspond to /apaniyāka-maj/ and /niyākam-maj/. These phonological transcriptions appear in Schmitt 2009: 192, but in

Lecoq 1974: 34, Lecoq 1983: 32-34, the /ǎ/ going back to an ancient close syllable nucleus was no longer pronounced: Anc. Ir. **abarat* > OP *abar*, spelled <a-b-r>. Hence, our conventional transcription of the last neutralized minimal pair, i.e. /ǎ/~ā/, with /a/, by analogy with the Avestan outcomes of Old Ir. pre-pausal /ǎ/, namely <ō>, that hints at a velarized allophone (Avestan seems to preserve the ancient quantity of pre-pausal /ǎ/, Hofmann & Forssman 1996: 70-72). According to Meillet & Benveniste 1931: 96, Diakonoff 1970: 108, Hinz 1973: 25 and Kurylowicz 1964: 563-564, the Aramaic principle of *mater lectionis* was consistently employed here. On this 'otiose' use of final <a> (see the unexpected spelling <p-u-ç-a> instead of <p-u-ç> in A²Hb), cf. Schmitt 1999: 74: "deren überschüssiges Auslaut-a [i.e. in <a-p-d-a-n-a> in A²Sa] dürfte am einfachsten eine rein graphische Erklärung finden, die Annahme der Hinzufügung eines a-Zeichens am Wortende wie in /puçā/ (statt Nom. Sing. /puça/ 'Sohn') A²Hb oder /Pārsā/ (statt Nom. Sing. /Pārsa/ 'Persien') AmH 5 (vgl. Kent 1953, 22b §53). Da die Auslautbelege für dieses Phänomen sich auf spätachaimenidische Inschriften konzentrieren, zeugt dies wohl von einer gewissen Unsicherheit in der Schreibung des Wortauslautes -, offenbar in folge der Diskrepanz zwischen tatsächlicher Aussprache und angestrebter 'klassischer' Sprachform". Despite some differences regarding the phonological interpretation, our proposal resembles Ilya Gershevitch's one (Gershevitch 1988), who distinguished two phonemes in final position: /a/ (written <C-a>) and /æ/ (written <C>). The latter could also be an /ə/, as rightly observed by Gershevitch 1988: 71 fn. 13.

⁹ On these "irrational" preterital forms, cf. Schmitt 1999: 75-77 ("alles in allem, zeigt sich offensichtlich also auch bei dieser Form wieder das Ergebnis des bereits fortgeschrittenen Flexionsverfalls. Der Autor dieses Textes [i.e. A²Sa] scheint, wo er nicht auf das vorgefundene Formular zurückgreifen konnte, mit seiner Fähigkeit zur Abfassung eines korrekten altpersischen Satzes bald am Ende gewesen zu sein. Er hat anscheinend noch gewußt, daß er für, 'ich habe gemacht/errichtet' eine Form mit /akuna.../ zu wählen hatte. Aber bei der Endung war er überfordert") and 81 (on <a-k^u-v-n-š-a-š>). The verb <a-k^u-v-n-š-a-š> is a "forme aberrante" according to Steve 1987: 96.

¹⁰ See Schmitt 1999: 77-78. Quite astonishingly, these marginal forms have not been considered in the thorough analysis of Allegri & Panaino 1995.

Schmitt 1999: 74 both forms are – correctly in our opinion – marked by an asterisk. Schmitt argues that:

im Wortausgang unvollständige Formen finden sich auch in den beiden Verwandtschaftstermini n-y-k-m statt */niyākam-maj/ Akk. Sing., ‘meinen Großvater’ und a-p-n-y-a-k-m statt */apaniyāka-maj/ Nom. Sing., ‘mein Urgroßvater’, deren Schluß-m, d.h. /-m/ oder /-ma/, offenbar für enklitisches /-maj/ ‘mein’ steht. Dies ergibt sich zwingend daraus, daß einerseits /apāniyaka-/ als Subjekt im Nom. Sing. steht, also Teil eines weiteren (enklitischen) Lexems, nicht einer Endung ist und daß andererseits Akk. Sing. n-y-k-m wegen der elamischen Wiedergabe nu-ya-ak-kam-mi nicht den bloßen Akkusativ */niyākam/ reflektieren kann, sondern offenbar für */niyākam-maj/, ‘mein Großvater’ steht. [...]. Zugleich zeigt die elamische Wiedergabe aber auch, daß im Altpersischen das enklitische Pronomen noch gesprochen, daß die Form also offenbar im Auslaut nur graphisch verkürzt worden ist (Schmitt 1999: 74-75).

In fact, either of these spellings traces back to an enclitic /-m/ ‘my’ according to the PMP phonology, whereas the latter lexeme is a “zero-form” plus the enclitic: /niyāk-am/.

4. There is good reason to assume that all these apparently-incongruous spellings were a sort of “graphical mask”, hinting at an identical phonological value. This is the systemic proposal that we put forward, in order to capture all the phenomena at issue.

The phonological reference of these “cuneiform masks” was straightforwardly the loss of final syllable nuclei and rhymes, most likely due to the action of a strong stress. It corresponds to the increasing “clean-up” process (процесс “стирания”) evoked by Oranskij in his *Vvedenie*:

а поскольку основные элементы флективной системы сосредоточены именно в конце слова (падежные, родовые и прочие окончания), то процесс “стирания” конца слова неизбежно привел к постепенному разрушению флексии (Oranskij 1960: 141, cf. Oranskij 1977).

Hence, it can be inferred that the underlying phonological strings or phonological references of all these spellings were typically MP forms, like *būm*, *asmān*, *pardēd*, *im*, *Dārayv* (cf. <d-a-r-y-v-š-h-y-a, i.e. *Dārayvē*, see below),¹¹ *Artaxšas*, *pus*, *apadān*, *abyapar*, *Anāhit*, *akunav*, *nīstāy* etc. No doubt,

¹¹ The restoration of a PMP form *dārayv* (or eventually *dārēv*) for the ‘Thronname’ seems preferable on the basis of the Greek *Nebenüberlieferung*, see Schmitt 2011:

the written structure of these tentatively reconstructed PMP words recalls Michael Back's "*Spätpersische Orthographie*" (Back 1978: 4, but see fn. 3), with reference to the consonantal profile of the words, at least in pārsik inscriptions and in Book-Pahlavī texts.

It sounds somewhat paradoxical that, apart from Prods Skjærvø's comments, the only scholar who rightly interpreted the 'quasi-alloglotto-graphy' of these late OP monuments was Ernst Herzfeld. The paradox is that his opinion was applied to a forgery, namely A¹I. Herzfeld brilliantly observed as follows:

also wurden zur seit dieser inschrift keine endungen mehr gesprochen. Ihre schreibung oder nichtsschreibung ist beliebig, meist falsch, nur eine erinnerung, ein ungrammatischer archaismus. Man sollte also lesen: 'artaχšāθ^r χšāθ vazrk χšāθ χšāθān χšāθ daihūn χšēršē χšāθē puθ^r χšēršē dāreyav χšāθē puθ^r haχāmaniši ē im bātugar sēm viθī krt' [...]. Die inschrift, die altpersisch gelesen in grammatik und syntax vollkommen fehlerhaft ist, ist also, wenn mittelpersisch gelesen, richtig. Daraus ist der schluss zu ziehen, dessen tragweite ich sehr hervorheben möchte, dass schon unter Artaxerxes I. 465-424 mittelpersisch, nicht mehr altpersisch gesprochen wurde (Herzfeld 1935: 4; emphasis is mine, M.M.).

Unfortunately, no one followed Herzfeld's hunch.¹² Perhaps most striking of all is the fact that recently edited studies, focussed on OP grammar, continue to avoid any reference to the systemic features of Late Achaemenid inscriptions. It is hardly conceivable that such authors are repeating

177-181 (with literature). In Book-Pahlavī the outcome of the ancient Darius's name is spelled <d'r'y> (Nyberg 1974: 58a), see for instance *Kārnāmak i Artaxšīr i Pāpakān* 1, 6 (Čunakova 1987: 38): *ut hač tōhmak (i) Dāray i Dārayān* (the second *aleph* must be read as a *scriptio plena*); this form recurs also in one of the most ancient MP inscriptions (a silver bowl edited by Skjærvø, who argued for a medieval "Thronname" *Dārayan*, apparently a patronymic, instead of the common reading *Dārēw* or *Dāray*, "since there hardly is any difference between *n* and *w* on the coins either from this period [viz. 1st century B.C.] or later", Skjærvø 1997: 94b); the name also recurs in the Persis *fratarakas*' coins (<d'r'yw>, cf. Seelwood 2006: 303 and 317).

¹² Schaeder 1935: 490 and Schmitt 2007: 86 (who severely condemned Herzfeld's attempt as "ungeheuerlich"), did not agree with Herzfeld's own linguistic interpretation of the inscriptional data.

de facto old-fashioned assertions which prevailed in our studies from Spiegel onwards.

Thus, Friedrich von Spiegel in the first edition of his *Altpersischen Keilschriften* opined that the “nicht unbedeutende Anzahl von theils grammatischen, theils orthographischen Abweichungen” in Artaxerxes II and III’ inscriptions could be treated “ohne Bedenken sämmtlich als Sprachverschlechterungen” (Spiegel 1862: 112). Moreover, instead of mere errors (“blosse Fehler”), Spiegel preferred to consider these alleged deviations “neuer Formen”, on account that “sich die altpersische Sprache selbst verschlechtert und ihre ursprüngliche Reinheit verloren habe” (Spiegel 1862: 113; the author also provides a brief grammatical sketch of these “Abweichungen”). But Spiegel’s linguistic *finesse* was soon forgotten.¹³

Few decades after, Hans Heinrich Schaeder found “die Inschriften [...] an grammatischer Fehlern schlimmster Art so reich” (Schaeder 1931: 640), Herzfeld, referring to A²Hd, wrote: “die inschrift ist so ungrammatisch, daß man sie nicht mehr genau übersetzen kann” (Herzfeld 1938: 50); Kent cited the “corrupted form” of the late monuments (see Kent 1953: 6b); Meillet and Benveniste pointed out that Artaxerxes II’s inscriptions were “incorrectes”, and “quant à celle d’Artaxerxes III, elle [scil. la langue] est barbare” (Meillet & Benveniste 1931: 25); not to mention Pierre Lecoq, who repeatedly wrote about “erreurs grammaticales” in Ariaramnes’ apocryphal inscription (see Lecoq 1974: 48 and Lecoq 1997: 124).

We likewise encounter the same questionable expressions in modern scholars. Manfred Brust in his OP historical grammar simply condemns “verfehlte Schreibungen” (Brust 2018: 10) such as <š-a-y-t-a-m> in A³Pa 4, and <p-r-d-y-d-a-m> in A²Sd^{a-d} 3, and does not make any further effort to explain these “mistakes” from a purely linguistic point of view. Jan Tavernier correctly underlines the existence of a wide range of spoken varieties throughout the Achaemenid Empire; this notwithstanding, he adds that “Old Persian inscriptional language, which was rather artificial (i.e. did not reflect the spoken language very well) in the elder inscriptions, now reveals some grammatical mistakes” (Tavernier 2013: 639). Prods Skjærvø, despite a superficial reference to the “‘wrong’ orthography, especially endings” in the Late cuneiform inscriptions (which he terms “proto-Middle-Persian”, see Skjærvø 2009: 47), correctly remarks the special role

¹³ Spiegel’s position was reaffirmed in his “zweite vermehrte Auflage” (cf. Spiegel 1881: 126–127).

of “late OP” throughout the diachrony of Ancient Iranian, albeit stigmatising the “bad data” at our disposal:

the inscriptions from Artaxerxes II (404–359) on are written in what is clearly a post-Old Persian/proto-Middle Persian stage of language (see Schmitt 1999: 59–118; Skjærvø 1999b [2002]: 158–161). Those from Artaxerxes I and Darius II are less clear; they are written in a late-Old Persian form, as seen from the thematic forms such as *dārayavaušahayā* and some grammatical constructions, but they are too short and formulaic to tell us much (Skjærvø 2009: 59).¹⁴

Finally, in their remarkable essay on Persian linguistic history, Maggi and Orsatti have noticed that “grammar and spelling mistakes frequently found in the inscriptions of Artaxerxes I (465–24), II (404–359), and III point to a language already approaching Middle Persian with confusion and loss of endings and conflation of different antecedents” (Maggi & Orsatti 2018: 16).¹⁵

5. Admittedly, within this rather discouraging scenario, Rüdiger Schmitt is the only scholar who has been intensively concerned with this issue. Yet according to the aforementioned Skjærvø’s opinion, in treating Late Achaemenid inscriptions, his works repeatedly emphasize their “serious grammatical faults” or “‘corrupt’ forms (incorrect endings, hybrid genitive

¹⁴ Cf. also the online handbook Skjærvø 2016: 139: “the inscriptions of Artaxerxes the II and his successors contain numerous forms that are incorrect by the standard of the inscriptions of Darius I and Xerxes I. What we are dealing with is in fact a post-Old Persian stage of the language (or pre-Middle Persian), which already has its own morphology, which is barely disguised by pseudo-Old Persian orthography”. On the contrary, an echo of the mainstream position is reflected in Fear 2015: 83 (“blatant grammatical errors”).

¹⁵ Against Lecoq’s sceptical observations on the OP noun <p-r-d-y-d-a-m> ‘paradise’ in A²Sd, Antonio Panaino rightly defended Schmitt’s interpretation, by rejecting the idea that behind the OP form there was a transitive verb. In his article Panaino repeatedly quotes the “mistakes” of Artaxerxes II’s inscription at Susa (Panaino 2012: 142 and 146), arguing for “a certain corruption/evolution of the O.P. language towards a new linguistic stadium in between a sort of Later Old Persian and Old Middle Persian”. Panaino adds that “the mixture of a decaying severity in the selection of the scribes and the new status of the real language might produce as final result the highly corrupted texts we can presently read in the attested materials belonging to the times of Artaxerxes” (Panaino 2012: 146). Panaino largely agrees here with Schmitt’s own opinions.

forms, etc.)” (Schmitt 2004: 718). More clearly, in his article in *Compendium linguarum Iranicarum*, Schmitt asserts as follows:

in der Zeit nach Xerxes I. beginnt allem Anschein nach bereits die Weiterentwicklung des Altpersischen zum Mittelpersischen hin. Man verwendete damals zwar weiterhin in traditioneller Weise das Altpersische, aber eine aktive Beherrschung dieser Sprache der ‘Väter’ war nicht mehr voll gewährleistet. Nur so lassen sich die mitunter haarsträubenden grammatische Fehler in der Sprache der spätachaimenidischen Inschriften, v.a. bei Artaxerxes III. Das Musterbeispiel solcher ‘barbarischer’ Sprache ist die einsprachige, in vier praktisch textgleichen Exemplaren vorliegende Inschrift A³Pa (Schmitt 1989: 60).

These statements have been stressed by Schmitt in his booklet *Die iranische Sprachen in Geschichte und Gegenwart* (where he talks of “teilweise gravierende grammatische Fehler”, Schmitt 2000: 34) and, above all, in what can be considered the unique attempt so far to fully describe the language of the Late Achaemenid corpus, namely the large chapter *Das spätachaimenidische Altpersisch* included in his *Beiträge zu altpersischen Inschriften*. Schmitt’s approach and arguments are unambiguously summarized at the very beginning of his essay:

der einzig richtige Weg kann meines Erachtens nur der sein – der im folgenden dann auch eingeschlagen werden soll –, das gesamte spätachaimenidische Textcorpus vorzulegen, sämtliche auffälligen, d.h.: von der ‘klassischen’ Norm abweichenden Formen zusammenzustellen und diese ‘Fehler’ dann genau zu analysieren. Dabei wird sich zeigen, daß man sorgfältig differenzieren muß und nicht jede falsche Form schon als ein Zeugnis für fehlerhafte Sprache und für Sprachverfall betrachten darf (Schmitt 1999: 60).

The brief historical and methodological introduction is immediately followed by a close inspection of seventeen inscriptions on different materials: A¹I (i.e. “Artaxerxes I incerto loco”, see Kent 1953: 113 and 153, a group of four silver bowls whose authenticity is hotly disputed: Schmitt is firmly convinced that the inscription is a forgery, Schmitt 1999: 61, Sims-Williams 2001: 189-192, Schmitt 2007: 82-93 and Schmitt 2009: 31 [VA^{1e}]), AVs a (which Mayrhofer conclusively assigned to Artaxerxes III, cf. Mayrhofer 1978: 28-29), VA^{1f}a (whose *editio princeps* was furnished by Sims Williams 2001: 187-189, see Schmitt 2009: 31), D²Sa, D²Ha, D²Hb (subsequently Schmitt regarded this inscription as a forgery, Schmitt 2007: 45-50), A²Sa, A²Sb, A²Sc, A²Sd, A²Ha, A²Hb, A²Hc, A³Pa, A³Pb, AmH and AsH, which the

great majority of scholars nowadays consider “authentic forgeries” (“zwar ‘echt’, aber nicht authentisch”, Schmitt 2007: 25). A short “Bilanz” concerning the “*spätaltpersische Sprachformen*” concludes this extensive chapter. Schmitt’s own conclusions deserve to be cited, since they exhaustively outline the historical and philological framework of the small *corpus*:

die Texte nämlich nicht durchgehend von derartigen spätaltpersische Spracherscheinungen ‘infiziert’ sind. Als solche Sonderformen des Spätaltpersische werden wir jene bezeichnen, die sich durch Abweichungen von der Norm der klassisch-altpersischen Sprache auszeichnen, bei denen den Textautoren und -redaktoren also, aus welchem Grund auch immer, der Anschluß an ihre Vorbilder nicht gelungen ist. Denn bekanntlich ist für die altpersischen Inschriften überhaupt typisch und den späteren Texten in ganz besonderem Maße eigentümlich ihre Stereotypie und Formelhaftigkeit: Oft werden dabei in den späten Texten die traditionellen Formeln unverändert übernommen – bei den mit /θāti/ beginnenden gewöhnlichen Redeeinleitungsformeln etwa findet sich offenbar niemals irgendeine Auffälligkeit –, mitunter werden sie adaptiert und umgebildet, nur selten werden neue, jedenfalls für die ältere Zeit nicht nachweisbare Formulierungen geschaffen. Die Texte bieten demzufolge insgesamt ein auffällige sprachliches Gemisch (Schmitt 1999: 111-112).

To sum up this point, the debatable method which is commonly employed to approach this peculiar “Text-Sorte”, is the one of filtering linguistic “pathologies” – so to speak – through the “canonical” Persian. As a matter of fact, a broad consensus exists among scholars, that we may reliably single out phono-morphological and syntactic phenomena, which seem to “affect” the “normal” OP “*Kunstsprache*” (notice Schmitt’s terminology: “von Spracherscheinungen ‘infiziert’ sind”).¹⁶

¹⁶ In several passages of his *Beiträge* Schmitt remarks that the PMP features go back to a spoken variety, that was strongly distant from the “classical Old Persian”, see for instance Schmitt 1999: 74 (“infolge der Diskrepanz zwischen tatsächlicher Aussprache und angestrebter ‘klassischer’ Sprachform”), 84 (“schon gesprochene /šāt/”), 94-98 (a broad and thorough discussion on the forms <b-u-m-a-m>, <š-a-y-t-a-m>, <a-s-m-a-n-a-m>: “für diese der gesprochenen Umgangssprache angehörende Form */šāti-/ hat der – wie oben anlässlich /būmi-/ schon besprochen – nicht erst mittelpersische, sondern offenbar schon in spätachaimenidische Zeit eingetretene Endungsverlust dann zu /šāt/ geführt”, Schmitt 1999: 97), 108 (with regard to AmH: “die meisten der sonstigen Anstöße betreffen falsche Endungen bzw. Wortausgänge oder falschen Kasusgebrauch, lassen sich

6. Crucially, these apparently “deviant” facts are scattered in non-formulaic portions of the inscriptions: in those sections the scribes were forcefully obliged to use words, constructions, and theonyms, which were absent in the official archives of Achaemenid realm and cannot be traced back to Darius and Xerxes’ cuneiform monuments.¹⁷ Anyway, a fully satisfying and, above all, systemic description of PMP has been left aside until today, even though it would acquire a great significance for OP scholarship.

A highly intriguing parallel may be quoted with close connection to the Late Achaemenid documents. Indeed, the spelling usages attested in this

also zusammenfassen als Zeugnisse für den in der Umgangssprache schon erfolgten Endungsverlust und den (in mangelnder Kasus- und Genusunterscheidung manifestierten) Zusammenbruch des Deklinationssystem”), 113 (“die altiranischen Endungen, genauer: die Auslautsilben ab dem Silbengipfel, wohl infolge der Fixierung eines starken Druckakzentes auf der Pänultima, nicht mehr gesprochen wurde”). See also Schmitt 2007: 28, 38 and 80. The arguments in de Vaan & Lubotsky’s 2012: 195, are almost identical: “in the inscriptions of the later kings (after Xerxes I) we find a number of orthographic and grammatical errors as compared with the older texts. It may be surmised that the spoken language had changed fundamentally, and that the phonology at least had reached a stage which we later find reflected in Middle Persian. In other words, this period witnessed the continued attempt to use OP as a written, ceremonial language, although the text composers were no longer fluent in the language”.

¹⁷ See Schmitt 1999: 66 (“der gleiche Fehler [i.e. the use of <p-u-ç> as a Genitiv] findet sich in anderen genealogischen Aufzählungen dieser Art aus spätachaimenidischer Zeit, für die es in ‘klassischen’ altpersischen Texten aber kein Vorbild gibt”), 77 (“der Autor dieses Textes [i.e. A²Sa] scheint, wo er nicht auf das vorgefundene Formular zurückgreifen konnte, mit seiner Fähigkeit zur Abfassung eines korrekten altpersischen Satzes bald am Ende gewesen zu sein”), 93 (“zum Teil sind Formen und Formeln [i.e. in A³Pa] zwar offenbar von älteren Vorbildern übernommen worden, aber selbst in solchen alten Standardformeln finden sich die auffälligsten Neuerungen. Und besonders ‘ungrammatische’ Passagen sind dort zustandegekommen, wo ältere Formeln angepaßt oder verändert werden mußten oder wo überhaupt neue Formulierungen nötig waren”), 111-112 (“als solche Sonderformen des Spätpersischen werden wir jene bezeichnen, die sich durch Abweichungen von der Norm der klassisch-altpersischen Sprache auszeichnen, bei denen den Textautoren und -redaktoren also, aus welchem Grund auch immer, der Anschluß an ihre Vorbilder nicht gelungen ist. Denn bekanntlich ist für die altpersischen Inschriften überhaupt typisch und den späteren Texten in ganz besonderem Maße eigentümlich ihre Stereotypie und Formelhaftigkeit”).

small cuneiform *corpus* are quite similar to the ones proper to the transitional *scriptae* of proto-Romance texts during the Late Latin and Early Middle Age stages. Actually, all available data reveal that both Persian and Romance scribes had to face the same challenging task, namely transcribing a new linguistic variety by means of an ancient script.

Apart from Roger Wright's "two norms-theory", which was disproved by the great majority of Latin scholars,¹⁸ it is an established fact that we are dealing here with two writing traditions, the Latin and the OP, which became fairly inadequate to mirror the linguistic continuity. Consequently, both scripts – Latin and Old Persian norms – developed a sort of "masking" device, i.e., a biunivocal correspondence between broad graphic chunks on one side (basically words, including simplified or "zero" inflectional morphemes) and phonological segments on the other side. Bear in mind that these new graphic correspondences, though adequate for the synchronic oral reality, deleted any one-to-one correspondence between single graphic unities (typically letters of the alphabet) and single phonological unities (which, given the nature of the cuneiform script, were mainly syllables rather than phonemes). Thus, either script was forced to use heterographic devices.

During the Pre-Carolingian and Carolingian era, the so-called "*circa romançum*" Latin¹⁹ aimed to reproduce the proto-Romance oral segments with specific conversion rules: «later evidence – Wright noticed – suggests that SAECULUM in a written Spanish text of the ninth century is more likely to represent a vernacular [sjeglo] than [sekulum]. Noone wrote *sieglo* in the ninth century; noone writes *orindzh* or *nait* nowadays; because noone is taught to write without also being taught how to spell» (Wright 1982: 50). This spelling phenomenology was extensively analyzed by Romance scholars with special regard to early medieval charters and inscriptions.

As Francesco Sabatini argued many decades ago (Sabatini 1968), the language of notarial documents includes two textual categories.²⁰ The first

¹⁸ Cf. Mancini 1994a: 612 fn. 14-15, where the scientific discussion is accurately reported.

¹⁹ For this definition see Avallé 1970: vii-xv.

²⁰ On the spelling phenomenology in the Latin charters see Sabatini 1963-1964, Sabatini 1965, Sabatini 1978, Mancini 1994b: 15-32, Sornicola 2012: 19-27. A very interesting case of "Greek masking" in a Proto-Romance context has been now investigated by Cuzzolin & Sornicola 2018.

one concerns those parts of the text, which are oft-repeated formulae, copied from previous models and therefore generally more “correct” or closer to the standard *scripta*. The other section of charters roughly dating from 6th century onwards, was called “parti libere” by Sabatini. These “free” sections normally deal with specific details of the legal transactions and are written in “*scripta Latina rustica*”, that is a less formal technique of spelling. Within these “free sections”, several vernacular forms emerge, despite the official orthography. Once the spelling rules were precisely fixed, allographic chunks, such as <quod> → /kko/, <formaticum> → /formadzə/ in notarial formulae or glossaries etc. or, more rarely, fully-fledged heterographic segments occur, such as <HIC> → /kwi/, <COTIDIE> → /ɔɲɲi dʒorno/ etc. occur. Thus, the underlying phonological segments may be easily reconstructed thanks to these projecting rules. See, for instance, rhythmic poems like the *Rhythmus de vita Sancti Zenonis*, the *Chant of San Farone* or the *Laudes regiae* from Soissons where the proto-Romance strings, albeit the masking effect of “*scripta rustica*”, become very transparent and perfectly traceable from a phonological point of view.

In the light of the aforementioned parallelism, Brandenstein-Mayrhofer’s statement about the Late Achaemenid *corpus* (we should also recall Herzfeld’s own contribution to this debate quoted above) seems to satisfactorily account for the linguistic situation,²¹ hinting that the cuneiform scribes made an attempt to reproduce the PMP by OP “spelling masks” (as we name them):

bei Artaxerxes III (4. Jh. v. Chr.) erkennt man die Entwicklung zum Mp. daran, dass bei den Versuchen, die gesprochenen Formen ins Ap. zurückverwandeln, verkehrte Lautgesetze usw. angewendet wurden. Das ap. **būmiš* wurde damals schon wie mp. *būm* gesprochen. Daher kam es zur falschen Akkusativbildung *imām būmām* “diese Erde hier” (Brandenstein & Mayrhofer 1964: 14).²²

²¹ Wilhelm Brandenstein tried to describe the main structural features of Late OP in his commentary to some recently-discovered cuneiform inscriptions published at the beginning of the 1930s (Brandenstein 1932: 15-19). Worth noticing was his list of PMP grammatical phenomena: final long vowels shortening, final short vowels dropping (e.g. *apadān*), overall collapse of noun inflection (“die ganze Flexion verschwand; so vertritt in der ‘Ariâramnes’-Inschrift (s. o.) der Nominativ andere Kasus”, Brandenstein 1932: 16); overall collapse of pronoun inflection etc.

²² In Brandenstein & Mayrhofer, nevertheless, the references to linguistic “mistakes” of these late inscriptions usually recur, see Brandenstein & Mayrhofer 1964:

According to our hypothesis, PMP inscriptions represent another case of “alloglottography” in the Achaemenid writing culture,²³ provided that “one can still argue that most scripts are ill-equipped to write precisely the very languages for which they are conceived”, as Gonzalo Rubio has recently claimed (Rubio 2006: 36).

7. From a structural point of view, in the late Achaemenid language or PMP the tense-based alignment which was typical of the Early MP regularly works. According to Haig, “a tense-based alignment split, affecting transitive verbs, and involving some kind of ergativity, in those clauses based on verb stems etymologically derived from a participle (in most of the languages now a ‘past’ or ‘perfective’ verb stem)” (Haig 2017: 465). It is a well-known fact that Iranian languages and dialects are typologically characterized by a basic stem opposition, which exhibits a two-stem verbal system: a present stem, on which present tenses, future tenses, and in some languages a past imperfective (e.g. in Taleshi), are based, and a past stem, historically the reflex of the *ta*-participle. The latter goes back to an ergative construction, whilst the former shows a continuous nominative-accusative alignment.

In OP the “tense-based” split increasingly spreads across the texts: on one side, the present stems show a coherent nominative/accusative alignment and preserve the inherited synthetic forms; on the other side, for the past-tense, only the imperfect survives, whereas Old Iranian Aorist and reduplicated Perfect were almost extinct. Not surprisingly, the ergative construction occurs in a significant number of passages.

As Haig, Karimi and Jügel have repeatedly showed,²⁴ in the analytic verbal phrases (henceforth VP), which encode past tense references, OP exhibits constructions consisting of an inflected resultative participle plus a

89 (A³Pa is a “Beispiel des fehlerhaften, nicht mehr beherrschten Altpersisch der spätachämenidischen Inschriften”; PMP <b-u-m-a-m> occurs “in fehlerhafter Sprache”, cf. Brandenstein & Mayrhofer 1964: 111), 90 (AmHa, where “verweisen schon die sprachlichen Fehler, die denen des vorangegangenen Textstückes [viz. A³Pa] ähnlich sind, das Document in spätachämenidische Zeit”). According to Sen 1941: 177, “few apparently ungrammatical and late forms” occur in AmHa.

²³ This term was introduced by Gershevitch in his celebrated essay on the “elamitization” of OP spoken language, cf. Gershevitch 1979.

²⁴ Cf. Haig 2008: 41-55, Karimi 2012: 28-37, Jügel 2015: 75-81.

copular verb.²⁵ We distinguish two main types of ergative construction: (a) with an overt agent participant, and (b) without an agent participant.

In the first case the agentivity is commonly expressed by a noun or a personal pronoun that bears the Genitive/Dative case (henceforth G/D) and the patient noun corresponds to the Nominative of the relative pronoun, which takes anaphorically the patient participant as its head. The G/D agent pronoun follows the relative pronoun in (1); in (2) the agentive pronoun has been cliticized to the second position (Wackernagel’s Law) and the patient *hamaranam* is marked by the Nominative case co-referring to the past participle marked by the <-m> ending. Ultimately, in (3) we have evidence that, unlike the agent nouns in (1 and 2) which are pronouns, a common noun phrase in G/D plays the role of agentive participant too:²⁶

1. <t-y m-n-a k-r-t-m>
/tay mana kṛtam/
that.NOM 1.SG.G/D do.PTCPL
“that is what I have done” (DB § 8, 127);
2. <a-v-θ-a-š-a-m h-m-r-n-m k-r-t-m>
/avaθāšām hamaranam kṛtam/
3.PL.G/D battle.NOM fight.PTCPL.NOM
“then they have fought the battle” (DB § 28, 247);
3. <t-y m-n-a k-r-t-m u-t-a t-y-m-i-y p-i-ç k-r-t-m>
/tay mana kṛtam uta tayamai piç kṛtam/
that.NOM 1.SG.G/D do.PTCPL and that.NOM=1.SG.G/D father.G/D
do.PTCPL
“that is what I have done and that is what my father has done”
(XPa 19-20).

The selection of the G/D case-marker bearing the agentive role the active/stative alignment is explained by the Benefactive function assigned to the G/D in OP, as Benvenuto and Pompeo have pointed out: “questo caso [scil. the OP G/D], infatti, oltre a svolgere funzioni che comparativamente possiamo definire tipiche del genitivo, risulta in grado di esprimere i ruoli di Ricevente, Destinatario, Beneficiario ed Esperiente, tradizionalmente

²⁵ A highly accurate inspection of these constructions in the OP corpus is provided by Bavant 2014: 332-336.

²⁶ For the phonological transcription of OP cuneiform script, see above at fn. 8.

attribuiti al dativo” (Benvenuto & Pompeo 2011: 94, see also Benvenuto & Pompeo 2015: 17-20).

The ergative construction is still marginal in the OP verbal system, and it occupied a “relatively minor aspectual niche [...] the difference is simply that by Middle Iranian, the *ta-participle* verb forms were the only available alternative for clauses with past time reference, hence the unmarked choice for past transitive clauses. The ‘change’ thus involved the extension of an existing construction into new contexts, brought about by the disappearance of the competitors through loss of finite verb forms such as the Aorist” (Haig 2017: 473).

The ergative alignment becomes the unique past-tense option in Parthian and MP, and triggered or, better, distributionally reinforced the diptotic inflectional noun-morphology:²⁷ an unmarked case, the Direct, contrasted in some contexts with a marked case, the Oblique (a reflex of the OP G/D). Sims-Williams, Skjærvø, and Alberto Cantera (with reference to the earliest MP translations of Avestan texts) have consistently demonstrated the existence of a two-case system in nouns and pronouns.²⁸

The Direct/Oblique case distinction was still alive in the pārsīk inscriptions and partially in the Psalter, albeit lexically restricted (kinship names and I-II pers. pronouns).²⁹ The MP drift both in Manichaean and, partially,

²⁷ See Mancini 1992b: 13.

²⁸ Cf. Sims-Williams 1981: 167-171, Skjærvø 1983, and Cantera 2009: 26-29. An Early MP diptotic system going back to an opposition Direct case (< OP Nom. case) vs Oblique case (< OP G/D case) was also acknowledged by Huyse 2003: 75-76, Huyse 2005: 57-58; see the extensive discussion in Durkin-Meisterernst 2014: 197-203 (nouns) and 206-208 (pronouns); Skjærvø 2009b: 204-205 simply makes reference to Haig’s Stage 2 (with an imparisyllabic opposition between Direct and Oblique in sing. *pid* vs *pidar* ‘father’ and plur. *pidar* vs *pidarān*). Quite surprisingly, this topic is totally absent in Brunner 1977 and Weber 2007.

²⁹ Prods Skjærvø has demonstrated that the inscriptional varieties and the Pahlavī Psalter maintained the functional opposition between Direct and Oblique cases in the personal pronouns paradigm and that of kinship terms: sing. Direct case MP <’HY> (*brāt*) < Nom. **brātā* ‘brother’, MP <BRTH> (*duxt*) < Nom. **duxtā* ‘daughter’, MP <ANH> (*az*) < Nom. **azam* ‘I’; sing. Oblique case MP <ABYtr> (*pitar*) < Gen. **pitarahya*, MP <BRTr> (*duxtar*) < Gen. **duxtarahya*, MP <LY> (*man*) < Gen. **mana* (see Skjærvø 1983 and Jügel 2015: 183-187). The split ergativity hypothesis for OP /*mana* *kṛtam*/ constructions has also been claimed by Ciancaglini 2008: 31-35, who rightly, in my opinion, assumes that the *Reichsaramische* past participle *qṭyl* structures are morphological calques of the corresponding OP forms (actually, Ciancaglini 1987: 22-

in Book-Pahlavī texts was quite different and shifting towards the Modern Persian overall nominative-accusative alignment, as Palmira Cipriano keenly remarked in one of her last works.³⁰

23, was still sceptical about the Iranian thesis; on the origin of the Eastern Aramaic construction, also see Pennacchietti 1988 and Coghill 2016: 162-248, a highly recommended study for the closer investigation of ancient and modern data). The Aramaic construction is also a striking confirmation that the OP constructions were commonly interpreted by bilinguals as an ergative past tense of transitive verbs. Quite astonishingly, to my knowledge, only Keigo Noda has connected the value of the Aramaic heterograms <LY> and <LK>, namely MP *man* for the 1st Sing. Pers. Pronoun and *tō* for the 2nd Sing. Pers. Pron., with the Western Ir. ergative constructions (Noda 1979; the relevance of Noda’s brief article has been correctly highlighted by Bavant 2014: 367). The Aramaic frozen forms obviously trace back to personal pronouns with an agentive function in ergative constructions employed in Imperial Official Aramaic. These constructions were due to syntactic interference with the OP analytical past tense.

³⁰ Cf. Cipriano 2007: 54-57, where a handful of interesting examples of prepositional Object marking, both from Manichaean MP and Book-Pahlavī, were quoted and correctly evaluated against Brunner’s very superficial interpretations of the same data (Brunner 1977: 154-155 with reference to MP *rāy*, and 188-194 with reference to MP and Parth. *ō*). This structural analysis was previously suggested by Belardi 2004: 85-90. No doubt, the new Western Iranian nominative/accusative alignment typical of the New Persian stage (“thus Persian has gone full circle” says Haig 2010: 258), that coded the accusative function of the ancient grammatical subject by means of Parthian preposition *ō* or grammaticalisation of OP postposition *rādi* (> MP *rāy* > New Pers. *rā*), spread to the past tense constructions during the Middle Iranian era, as Belardi and Cipriano argued. However, as Jügel put forward, “diese sekundäre Markierung des direkten Objekts taucht stellenweise auch in der Ergativdomäne auf und führt somit zu einer Doppeloblique- oder sogar zu einer Akkusativ-konstruktion” (Jügel 2015: 182, see the broad discussion in Jügel 2015: 192-197, 213-219, and 330-342). According to the data thoroughly collected by Thomas Jügel, it seems that the grammaticalization process was still ongoing during the late MP period, although the philological ascertainment is quite complicated: “direkte Objekte sind zunächst unmarkiert. In späteren Texten finden sich dann Adpositionen, die bisweilen das direkte Objekt sowohl in Akkusativ- als auch in Ergativkonstruktionen markieren. Dieses ‘später’ genaue zu datieren, ist allerdings schwierig, weil Texte über die Entwicklung der Objektsmarker im Verlauf der mittelliranischen Epoche nur bedingt Zeugnis ablegen können (vgl. Kap. 1.2). Denn es ist nicht unwahrscheinlich, dass in der gesprochenen Sprache solche Grammatikalisierungsprozesse früher einsetzten und früher zum Abschluss kamen, als es die Datierbarkeit mancher Texte erscheinen lassen mag. Sporadisches Auftreten solcher Objektsmarker kann den Interpolationen späterer

Geoffrey Haig has reconstructed three different stages of case-marking in Middle-Iranian diachrony (Haig 2008: 100), which we report as follows:

	SING	PLUR
DIR	-∅	-∅
OBL	*-ē	-ān

Stage 1. Reconstructible for earliest Western Middle Iranian.

	SING	PLUR
DIR	-∅	-∅
OBL	-∅	-ān

Stage 2. Attested Early Western Middle Iranian.

	SING	PLUR
DIR	-∅	-ān
OBL	-∅	-ān

Stage 3. Late Western Middle Iranian.

Our claim is that the Oblique sing. case in Early MP (Haig's Stage 1) ought not be considered an "asterisk" form,³¹ namely a mere reconstruc-

Kopisten geschuldet sein, aber auch die graduelle funktionale Ausbreitung der Adpositionen repräsentieren. Zudem stellen manche Texte nicht einen einheitlichen Text dar, sondern weisen auch Pro- und Epiloge sowie Kolophone auf, die jüngeren Datums als der Kerntext sein können. Enzyklopädische Texte können leicht um einige Abschnitte erweitert worden sein" (Jügel 2015: 192-193). The process of late MP reanalysis from the ergative alignment to the accusative one in the past tense was also studied by Noda 1999.

³¹ The reconstruction of a diptotic noun inflection in Early Middle Persian is nowadays commonly accepted (see fn. 28 and 29). Friedrich Carl Andreas, as is well-known, was the first scholar to assume the existence of an Oblique case marked by an *-ē*-ending in Early Middle Persian, cf. Andreas 1894: 1794-1795; with regards to the Middle-Persian, his hypothesis was followed by Salemann 1895-1901: 275-276, Horn 1898-1901: 100, Mann 1906: LI-LII, Meillet 1900: 255-265, Gauthiot 1914-1923: 177-179, Benveniste 1929: 70 ("par la ruine des finales ils [i.e. the effects of stress] amèneront à une identité totale au singulier, le nominatif, le vocatif, l'accusatif et l'ablatif-instrumental, seul le génitif **-ahya*, réduit à **-ē*, gar-

tion, since the PMP inscriptions already testify to the concrete existence of an $\bar{e}$ -marked case, both functionally and formally.

8. Prods Skjærvø in his remarkable essay on the OP verbal system showed that from a purely synchronic point of view the synthetic forms of Aorist (a-d-a-r-š-i-y> in DPe 8, <a-j-mⁱ-i-y-a> in DPd 19 and the oft-occurring <a-d-a>) and Perfect (c-x-r-i-y-a> in DB I 50) became soon mere linguistic fossils. Simultaneously, the imperfect tense survived as the unique synthetic preterite, “which denotes both the progressive, non-completed action and anteriority and completed action” (Skjærvø 1985a: 219). In PMP, however, it seems likely to assume that the imperfect was drastically reduced to just a single form, i.e. *akunav*. This form occurs in the inscriptions marked by several “pseudo-endings” as we have already demonstrated above.

Moreover, it is worth noticing that in PMP verbal constructions (unlike OP), two actants of the verb, the S(ubject) and the O(bject) plus the core of the VP, i.e. the Past Participle, exhibit reduced inflectional markers. Thus, both S and O correspond to the new Direct Case encoded by a “zero”-ending. This means that a fully-fledged ergative alignment within a “split-ergativity” system, where A(gentive) ≠ S = O, is going to prevail.

This innovative inflectional set of case-markers is apparent in a handful of “free” or “non-formulaic” sections of the stereotyped late cuneiform inscriptions according to the aforementioned Proto-Romance textual distribution.³² If we leave aside the clause <u-t-m-i-y k-r-t-m> in A²Sd 4, where the last word is a noun and not a participle (“my building” Kent, and “mein

dant une forme propre [...]. L’iranien moyen, dans son ensemble, opposera au singulier un cas direct (nominatif-accusatif) de désinence zéro à un cas oblique de désinence *-ē”), Henning 1958: 67-69, Nyberg 1974: 277 (where an inflections as follows is postulated: sing. Direct case MP *asp* < OP *aspah*, *aspō*, *aspam*; sing. Obl. case MP *aspē* < OP *aspahya*; plur. Direct case MP *asp* < OP *aspāh*; plur. Obl. case MP *aspān* < OP *aspānam*), Rastorgueva & Molčanova 1981: 58-59. A close connection between medieval evidences (among which Bactrian diptotic case morphology must be included) and Iranian modern dialects is underlined by Rastorgueva 1975: 121-162, see also the overall picture in Windfuhr 1990, Haig 2008: 131-199, and Korn 2017: 612-613. Andreas’ theory was deeply criticised by Hübschmann 1895: 272, and Bartholomae 1923: 18-43, see also Schaefer 1930: 64 fn. 3, Back 1978: 34-37.

³² Filippone in press is an interesting overall discussion about the formulaic patterns in OP inscriptions.

Werk” in Schmitt’s translation),³³ the ergative construction occurs only twice in A³Pa: <i-m-m u-s-t-š-n-a-m a-θ-g-n-a-m m-a-m u-p-a m-a-m k-r-t-a> (22-23), and <u-t-a t-y m-a-m k-r-t-a> (26). In both occurrences, the A (= personal pronoun), as the ergative alignment predicts, is expressed by a reduced form of the Oblique case /man/.

Furthermore, in both passages the morphological equivalence S = O throws light on the noun inflectional system and fits the requisites of an ergative construction.

As a matter of fact, on the ground of the loss of vocalic nucleus as well as of consonantal rhyme in the final syllables,³⁴ which was masked by spellings such as <x-š-a-y-θ-i-y> (in <h-y m-a-m x-š-a-y-θ-i-y a-h-y-a-y-a b-u-mⁱ-i-y-a v-z-r-k-a-y-a a-k^u-u-n-u-š>, D²Hb 7-9, note that the inscription could be a forgery), <t-y> instead of <t-y-a-m> (in <i-m-a-m d-h-y-a-u-m t-y a-d-m d-a-r-y-a-mⁱ-i-y>, D²Hb 26-28, an inscription suspected of being a forgery, cf. AmH 5 <i-y-m d-h-y-a-u-š p-a-r-s-a t-y a-d-m d-a-r-y-a-mⁱ-i-y>, <b-u-m-a-m> (A³Pa 2), <a-s-m-a-n-a-m> (A³Pa 3), <š-a-y-t-a-m> (A³Pa 4), <x-š-a-y-θ-i-y> (in <h-y m-a-m a-r-t-x-š-ç-a x-š-a-y-θ-i-y a-k^u-n-u-š>, A³Pa 5-6), the “ir-

³³ See Kent 1953: 155a, Schmitt 1999: 81, and Schmitt 2009: 195; see also Scheil 1933: 128 (“mon œuvre”), Sen 1941: 168 (“my palace”); Steve 1987: 96 (“ce que j’ai construit”) and Lecoq 1997: 274 (“ce que j’ai fait”) prefer the ergative interpretation. On this passage see also Filippone in press.

³⁴ Prods O. Skjærvø, on the ground of the epigraphic evidences, describes the PMP morpho-phonological features as follows: “loss of final consonants and probably vowels in endings, as evidenced by the indiscriminate use of short and long vowels and omission of final *m*: acc. sing. *imam bātugara* (A¹); *imam apadāna*, *apadānā imam*; *imām hadiṣ utā imām *ustacanām taya aθagainām*, *Artaxšaça* (A²); *imām būmām*, *avam asmānām*, *Artaxšaça xšāyaθiya*, *imam ustašanām aθaganām* (A³); 1st sing.: *n(i)stāya*, *akunā*, *akunavām*; 3rd sing.: *aθavā*; *akunaš*; 3rd plur.: *akunaiy(a)* < **akunavaya*” (cf. *akunavaya*”tā) (Skjærvø 2016: 140). De Vaan & Lubotsky 2012: 207 return to this brief grammatical sketch: “loss of word-final consonants and probably also vowels, as is demonstrated by the many anomalous nominal endings, such as acc.sg. *imām bumām* for **imām bumīm*, gen.sg. *puça* instead of *puçaḥaya*; restriction of the relative pronoun to the forms *haya* and *taya*; loss of the imperfect, as shown by the many anomalous variants of the 1sg.: *akunavām*, *akunā*, *akunā*, *akunai*, *akuvanašāša*, all for earlier *akunavam*. Other deviations from Darius’s norm may be due to decreasing familiarity with the original spelling conventions: final /-a/ written as <-a>: <p-u-ç-a> *puça*; /Ciy/ written as <C-y>: <n-y-k-> for **niyāka*; defective spelling after <Ci>: <mi-t-r> *Mitra* instead of <mi-i-t-r>”.

rational” forms <k-r-t-a> (instead of the expected <k-r-t-a-m>),³⁵ <i-m-m> (instead of the expected <i-m-a-m>), but also the syntactically incongruous <u-s-t-š-n-a-m a-θ-g-n-a-m> must be read as a “zero”-ending phrase. Thus, the underlying phonological PMP strings in A³Pa 22-23 and A³Pa 26 were respectively /im ustašn asangēn man up man kart/ and /ut tay man kart/.³⁶ So S sounds here identical to O in a transitive construction like <h-y i-m-a-m b-u-m-a-m a-d-a>, PMP /hay im būm ada/ in A³Pa 1-2 as well as <h-y a-v-m [sic] a-s-m-a-n-a-m a-d-a>, PMP /hay ō asmān ada/ in A³Pa 2-3.

As far as S is concerned, see the nominal clause <a-d-m a-r-t-x-š-ç-a> in A²Sb, A²Sd 1, where S encodes the same “zero”-case marker of O in the aforementioned transitive clause <h-y m-a-m a-r-t-x-š-ç-a x-š-a-y-θ-i-y a-k^u-n-u-š> (A³Pa 5-6) vs <h-y a-r-t-x-š-ç-a-m XŠ-m a-k^u-n-u-š> (A²Hc 4).

A small group of theonyms occur in A²Sa marked by a “zero”-morpheme, both with adnominal function (<v-š-n-a AM₁ a-n-h-t u-t-a mⁱ-θ-r> “by the favor of”, as head of the phrase in A²Sa 5) and the role of S in transitive clauses (<AM₁ a-n-h-t mⁱ-θ-r m-a-m p-a-t^u-u-v> “may protect me”, A²Sa 5-6; notice <AM₁>, namely /ōrmazd/, a non-inflected form masked by the ideogram; see also A²Ha 5 and 6, where the theonyms occur with both functions; in A²Sd 3-4 <a-n-h-i-t>, <mⁱ-t-r> function as S of a transitive clause.

9. The overextension of the Direct case can be observed in other passages, where the modifier systematically precedes the modified. This syntactic option represents a regular choice in Parthian, but not in MP,³⁷

³⁵ The grapheme <a> at the end of the written word does not make any sense from the phonological point of view, according to the major commentators: it is another graphic relic of the ancient *mater lectionis* principle, see also Jügel 2015: 324-325, who, however, prefers to argue for a nasalized [ã] behind <-a> in <k-r-t-a> (“möglichlicherweise hatte sich -am bereits zu einem Vokal entwickelt (ev. nasal /ã/)”). Marc Bavant simply notices that this construction in A³Pa “avec l’agent exprimé à l’accusatif au lieu du génitif-datif [...] n’apparaît qu’une fois et dans une inscription tardive considérée généralement comme ‘fautive’ (Artaxerxès III à Persépolis). L’accord du participe est également erroné” (Bavant 2014: 333).

³⁶ The spelling <u-t> without enclitics, is documented only in A²Sa 6 and confirms, in our opinion, a phonological reference /ut/.

³⁷ Cf. Brunner 1977: 10-19, Durkin-Meisterernst 2014: 263-271. Roland G. Kent, in his comment on the genealogies of A²Sb, A²Sd, A²Hb, A²Sh an A³Pa, says “apparently OP had by this time become virtually a dead language employed only in writing ceremonial official records, its spoken for having suffered a wearing down of the endings (seen very clearly in Pahlavi). With the loss of the genitive ending it was

where *izāfat* structure is overwhelmingly preferred. It is perfectly natural that the configurational device does not need an overt case-marking: see <h-y d-a-r-y-v-u-š XŠ p-u-ç-a> (namely PMP /ī Dārayv šāh pus/) in A²Hb, and in the late apocryphal AsHa 3-4: <a-r-i-y-a-r-m-n x-š-a-y-θ-i-y p-u-ç> (namely MP /ēraram šāh pus/). The former example shows an unexplained Nominative <d-a-r-y-v-u-š>, as well as the ideogram for ‘king’, without any phonetic complement, and the word for ‘son’ with redundant <a> (= /pus/); the latter example shows three nouns devoid of grammatical endings and referring to ‘zero’-case-markers. In the adnominal position the word order ‘modifier + head’ is canonical in OP (see Benvenuto & Pompeo 2011: 79-80).

A relation between head and modifier with ‘zero’-endings, merely by means of syntactic configuration, occurs also in a long genealogical passage in A³Pa 12-20: <a-d-m a-r-t-x-š-ç-a x-š-a-y-θ-i-y p-u-ç a-r-t-x-š-ç-a d-a-r-y-v-u-š x-š-a-y-θ-i-y p-u-ç d-a-r-y-v-u-š a-r-t-x-š-ç-a x-š-a-y-θ-i-y p-u-ç a-r-t-x-š-ç-a x-š-y-a-r-š-a x-š-a-y-θ-i-y p-u-ç : x-š-y-a-r-š-a d-a-r-y-v-u-š x-š-a-y-θ-i-y p-u-ç d-a-r-y-v-u-š vⁱ-š-t-a-s-p-h-y-a n-a-m p-u-ç vⁱ-š-t-a-s-p-h-y-a a-r-š-a-m n-a-m p-u-ç>; only the phrase <vⁱ-š-t-a-s-p-h-y-a n-a-m> (to be read putatively in PMP garb: /wīštaspē nām/), breaks the sequential chain of heads and modifiers with an Oblique insert, as in VA¹f^a where the Oblique <x-s-a-y-θ-i-y-h-y-a> is an adposition of <a-r-t-x-s-ç-a>, which precedes the head <vⁱ-i-θ-i-y-a> (in <a-r-t-x-s-ç-a x-s-a-y-θ-i-y-h-y-a vⁱ-i-θ-i-y-a>), see also A²Sb <d-a-r-y-v-u-š XŠ-h-y-a p-u-ç> and, respectively, A²Sd 2: <d-a-r-y-v-u-š XŠ-a-h-y-a p-u-ç>.

The distribution of the Oblique case in other late inscriptions should be highlighted, too. It is oddly overextended in:

a) D²Ha 12-16: <a-r-t-x-š-ç-a XŠ-h-y-a p-u-ç a-r-t-x-š-ç-a-h-y-a x-š-y-a-r-š-a-h-y-a XŠ-h-y-a p-u-ç x-š-y-a-r-š-a-h-y-a d-a-r-y-v-u-š-h-y-a XŠ-h-y-a p-u-ç>;

b) in D²Hb 18-23 (an inscription suspected of being a forgery), an identical genealogical sequence occurs, but the first patronymic is here written <a-r-t-x-š-ç-a-h-y-a>, so that <a-r-t-x-š-ç-a> in a) (= D²Ha 12) could be considered as a simple mistake for <a-r-t-x-š-ç-a-h-y-a> (see Schmitt 1999: 65);

natural to employ the nominative as a general case, as it had already been thus used in appositions” (Kent 1953: 98a).

c) in A²Sa 1-3: <d-a-r-y-v-u-š-h-y-a XŠ-h-y-a p-u-ç d-a-r-y-v-u-š-h-y-a a-r-t-x-š-ç-a-h-y-a XŠ-h-y-a p-u-ç a-r-t-x-š-ç-a-h-y-a x-š-y-a-r-c-h-y-a XŠ-h-y-a p-u-ç x-š-y-a-r-c-h-y-a d-a-r-y-v-u-š-h-y-a XŠ-h-y-a p-u-ç d-a-r-y-v-u-š-h-y-a vⁱ-i -š-t-a-s-p-h-y-a p-u-ç>; cf. also, A²Ha 2-4 (where the form <x-š-y-a-r-š-h-y-a> recurs, instead of <x-š-y-a-r-c-h-y-a>) and A²Hc 9-15, with the *varia lectio* <vⁱ-i-š-t-a-s-p-h-y-a n-a-m p-u-ç>.

The aforementioned inscriptions testify to a particular usage of the Oblique case in the genealogical lists, which deserves special attention. The semantic role of the G/D endings corresponds to those of Possessor and Experiencer:

- the first occurring pattern is (X)_{Direct} + Y_{Obl} + “king”_{Obl} + <p-u-ç>_{Direct} in a);
- the other sequences in b) and c) show the pattern X_{Obl} + Y_{Obl} + “king”_{Obl} + <p-u-ç>_{Direct}.

The form <p-u-ç> has been straightforwardly transferred from an earlier formula, such as, for instance the one in XPa 9-10: <d-a-r-y-v-u-š x-š-a-y-θ-i-y-h-y-a p-u-ç>.³⁸ The pattern is strikingly similar to some thematic parallels related to the king and his genealogy, which were found in the Sasanian pārsīk and pahlavīk inscriptions, as Skjærvø suggested many years ago (Skjærvø 1985b), see e.g. ŠKZ Pa 1: <’NE mzdzyzn ’LH’ šhypo [...] BRY mzdzyzn ’LH’ ’thštr>. An alternative but much less likely hypothesis might consider <p-u-ç> an analogical form of the Oblique, similar to <p-i-ç> “of the father” (< Anc. Ir. **piθra*>); it must be borne in mind that in MP *pus* was indeed assimilated to the -r- imparisyllabic kinship terms soon enough (see the inscriptional MP <BRTEr>, namely *pusar* in ŠKZ).

In a), b) and c) the Oblique modifier of the first adnominal construction has been copied in the following head, with an unexpected G/D case-ending: <d-a-r-y-v-u-š-h-y-a a-r-t-x-š-ç-a-h-y-a XŠ-h-y-a p-u-ç a-r-t-x-š-ç-a-h-y-a x-š-y-a-r-c-h-y-a XŠ-h-y-a p-u-ç>. This syntactic solution seems quite strange and it has never been fully explained so far.³⁹ In our opinion

³⁸ This explanation was already put forward by Marquart 1895: 670.

³⁹ Marquart 1895: 670, in order to account for the deviant syntactical structure, thought that <h-y-a> corresponded to the “article” /haya/, namely the pers. pronoun in *izāfat* construction. According to Kent 1953: 23, these constructions were “examples of anacoluthon”.

its aim necessarily consists of disambiguating the entire sequence, as far as co-reference is concerned. Kent seems to have got the point as far as he talks about the cases of A²Sa, A²SHa, A²SHc, of “the gen.[itive] *Dārayavauša-hyā* [which] is repeated as a basis of clarity” (Kent 1953: 98b).

As a matter of fact, a clause like *<d-a-r-y-v-u-š a-r-t-x-š-ç-a-h-y-a XŠ-h-y-a p-u-ç a-r-t-x-š-ç-a x-š-y-a-r-c-h-y-a XŠ-h-y-a p-u-ç>, with Direct case in head-slots, could not unambiguously indicate that the pair of occurrences of Artaxerxes’ name was actually referring to the same king within the genealogical list: ‘son of Artaxerxes the king, Artaxerxes [which one?] son of Xerxes’ and so on. As a matter of fact, the genealogical pattern in these late inscriptions is quite different from that of Darius and Xerxes,⁴⁰ where king’s genealogy was mainly declared through a patronymic segmentation: each block simply indicated that ‘X was father of Y’, by means of a monotonously repeated nominal clause, in order to avoid any possible confusion along the list: <m-n-a p-i-t-a vⁱ-š-t-a-s-p vⁱ-š-t-a-s-p-h-y-a p-i-t-a a-r-š-a-m a-r-š-a-m-h-y-a p-i-t-a a-r-i-y-a-r-m-n a-r-i-y-a-r-m-n-h-y-a p-i-t-a c-i-š-p-i-š c-i-š-p-a-i-š p-i-t-a h-x-a-m-n-i-š> (DB 2, 104-105, cf. DBa 5-8).⁴¹ Put differently, the repetition of G/D, instead of Direct case, also functions as a determining device, like a demonstrative pronoun: “son of Artaxerxes, of this Artaxerxes son of Xerxes, of this Xerxes son of Darius” and so on.

10. Rüdiger Schmitt, by treating the forms marked by the suffix <h-y-a> in Late Achaemenid inscriptions, argues for a “ganz agglutinierende Weise” (Schmitt 1999: 65) in cases like <d-a-r-y-v-u-š-h-y-a> or <a-r-t-x-š-ç-a-h-y-a>. Given the previous scientific literature, we are convinced that Schmitt’s statement is a very significant step forward in the interpretation of PMP spellings. Actually, in the major grammatical sketches of OP such as those of Kent and Skjærvø,⁴² the overwhelming opinion is, quoting from

⁴⁰ See Schmitt 1999: 66.

⁴¹ Slightly different patterns occur in DBa 3-4 (<vⁱ-š-t-a-s-p-h-y-a p-u-ç- a-r-š-a-m-h-y-a n-p-a>) and XPf 16-21 (<m-n-a p-i-t-a d-a-r-y-v-u-š d-a-r-y-v-h-u-š p-i-t-a vⁱ-š-t-a-s-p n-a-m a-h u-t-a vⁱ-š-t-a-s-p p-i-t-a a-r-š-a-m n-a-m a-h u-t-a vⁱ-š-t-a-s-p u-t-a a-r-š-a-m u-b-a a-jⁱ-i-v-t-m>).

⁴² See Spiegel 1862: 114: “ich lese *Dārayavusahyâ*, nicht *Dārayavushyâ*, das Wort ist meiner Ansicht nach in die Decl., der Wörter auf a übergegangen”; then, cf. Brandenstein 1932: 15 (with reference to ancient nouns with *ā*-Nominative ending), Kent 1953: 24b (“new formations for the genitive-presumably after the gen. *xšāyaθiyahyâ*, with which the genitives of the royal name were constantly associated”), Schweiger 1998: 503 fn. 17, Skjærvø 2007: 59 (“thematic forms”), Skjærvø

Cantera, that “the *-ahya* ending seems to have spread from the thematic nouns to the athematic ones” (Cantera 2009: 28), adding that “this emerges from the fact that starting with the inscriptions of Artaxerxes only the *-ahya* ending seems to have been productive and that the final *y* in I[nscriptional]M[iddle]P[ersian] was attached to all thematic and athematic nouns” (Cantera 2009: 28).⁴³

When Schmitt talks of “agglutination”, he is keenly aware of the prominently written nature of this issue.⁴⁴ However, quite surprisingly, his correct intuition is led to exaggeration, when he claims that phonetic complements in spellings like <XŠ-(y)-m>, <XŠ-(h)-y-a>, <XŠ-y-a-n-a-m> had some influence on the “agglutinating” Oblique phrases:

diese agglutinierende Bildung des Typs ‘Nom. + /-hyā/ mag übrigens zustandegekommen oder zumindest nahegelegt worden sein durch die logographisch Schreibung XŠ-h-y-a des Königstitels, die unschwer in Nom.-Form XŠ und Gen. Zeichen-h-y-a /-hyā/ zerfällt (Schmitt 1999: 65).

Without a shadow of a doubt, a purely spelling motivation of linguistic phenomena does not hold at all, and Schmitt’s view must be seriously

2016: 140. Werba discusses the “thematische Neubildungen” (according to his doubtful transcription) /dārayavaušahəyā/ and /ərtaxšačcāhəyā/ in Werba 2006: 264 fn. 15.

⁴³ According to Cantera “the beginning of this process can be dated quite early”, as it should appear in the G/D form <t^u-u-n^u-u-v-t-h-y-a> in DNb 9 and XPl 9-10 (Nom. <t^u-u-n^u-u-v-a> in DNB 10). However, the form /tunuwantahya/ is the outcome of a metaplasm from the *-nt- class into the more productive and more diagrammatically iconic *-ā- class. On the contrary, from a structural point of view, the PMP G/D of ancient athematic nouns can be hardly considered alike. Actually, the PMP cases do not provide any example of metaplasm: the spelling <d-a-r-y-v-u-š-h-y-a> cannot be interpreted, as Cantera does, as “the few athematic genetives attested alongside hav[ing] the ending *-haya*” (Cantera 2009: 28), since the G/D case-marker is attached to the Nominative and not to the consonantal theme.

⁴⁴ Schmitt had already suggested the “agglutination” theory in Schmitt 1989: 60: “fehlerhafte Formen gleicher Art, vornehmlich Nom. Sing. statt Gen. Sing. oder Genetiv-formen, bei denen -(a)hyā einfach an die Form des Nom. Sing. antritt (z. B. <d-a-r-y-v-u-š-h-y-a>)”. Schmitt’s arguments recall those of Sen: “note that dārayav(u)ša has become the stem; so xšayāršahyā etc.” (Sen 1941: 165). Schmitt’s agglutinating theory also resembles Brandenstein’s idea that <d-a-r-y-v-u-š> developed into a “Wortstumpf” and was inflected in accordance with the *Vištāspa*-model (Brandenstein 1932: 16).

questioned. A closer inspection of the PMP inscriptions suggests a widely divergent explanation. The impression one receives from these texts is that the new underlying MP morpho-syntactic structures can hardly be overestimated.

On the base of “cuneiform masks” like the apparent Nominatives <d-a-r-y-v-u-š>, <a-r-t-x-s-ç-a>, <x-š-y-a-r-š-a> (and *a fortiori* the ideogram <XŠ>), fully-fledged MP pronunciations of Direct Cases may be inferred, such as *Dārayv*, *Artaxšas*, and so forth. This is the only solution so far that accounts for a correct interpretation of our data. Otherwise, from a strictly linguistic point of view, forms like the alleged *Dārayavaušahya* (a “Nominative” plus “G/D ending”, according to Schmitt’s “agglutinating” hypothesis: notice that Schmitt takes the “phonological” argument so seriously that he is wondering about the reliability of a group /šh/, Schmitt 1999: 65!) would be absurd.

It is the “masking-hypothesis” that accounts perfectly for these so-called “erroneous” forms: Nominative strings like <d-a-r-y-v-u-š> turn out to be “masking-spellings” which hint at Direct cases with “zero”-ending. The <h-y-a> morpheme is directly attached to the new PMP stem: thus, <d-a-r-y-v-u-š-h-y-a> must be plausibly read /dārayvē/ and so forth.

With regards to the phenomena at issue, an interesting question arises about the <h-y-a> Oblique ending. By analyzing the spelling structure of <h-y-a>, Pierre Lecoq, returning after two decades to OP script problems, has recently stressed that the final <a> (for Ancient Iranian *-ā in open syllables) could not correspond to an effective long /ā/, according to Meillet & Benveniste and Brandenstein & Mayrhofer’s view (followed by Mittelberger, Hofmann, Hahn, Schmitt, Sims-Williams, Skjærvø, de Vaan & Lubotsky, and Brust).⁴⁵ We add that the use of <a> in initial, middle and final syllables goes back to Aramaic spelling norms, as we have demonstrated years ago in an article where Kurylowicz’s thesis of an overall neutralization of quantitative correlation in final syllables was defended (Mancini 1992a, see in this article fn. 8).

Lecoq maintains that in nexuses with enclitics such as <u-t-m-a-m>, <u-t-š-i-m> (see <u-t-a>), and <a-v-d-š-i-š> (see <a-v-d-a>) the real pronuncia-

⁴⁵ See Meillet & Benveniste 1931: 92, Brandenstein & Mayrhofer 1964: 28, Mittelberger 1965: 110-11, Hofmann 1976: 633-635, Hahn 1969: 62, Sims-Williams 1981: 174, Schmitt 1989: 67, Skjærvø 2009: 58, de Vaan & Lubotsky 2012: 198, and Brust 2018: 15; *contra* Hinz 1973: 25, Gershevitch 1988: 67-68 (where a sharp criticism is levelled against Sims-Williams’ hypothesis).

tion of /ǎ/ fully emerges. Moreover, he underlines the special behavior of month-names (or menonyms) preceding the head <m-a-h-y-a>, a behavior that had already been stressed by Meillet & Benveniste 1931: 92-93, Prosdocimi 1967: 34-35, and Hofmann 1976: 633:

ainsi les noms de mois sont-ils régulièrement écrits -hya, au génitif, alors que partout ailleurs on trouve -hyā. Il s’agit d’une orthographe où le nom du mois est traité comme un proclitique, voir même comme un premier élément de composition fléchi, malgré l’utilisation du trait de séparation des mots, dont l’usage peut être tardif. Il n’y a pas d’exception: āçiyāiyahya (DB § 18 89, §38 18); ādukanaišahya (DB §31 69); anāmakahya (DB §19 96, §25 26, § 29 56, §45 63); garmapadahya (DB §11 42, §36 7-8, §42 46); θuravāharahya (DB §26, 36, §27 41, §30 61, §41 39); viyaxanahya (DB §11 37, §35 98, §46 68) (Lecoq 2017: 220).

Furthermore, according to Lecoq, these spellings anticipate the MP fossilized -ē morphemes in words like *kārēzār* “battlefield” (< **kārahya*), *šabēxōn* “night expedition” (lit. “night blood”, < **xšapahya*): “il reste que le scribe a pu [viz., in the PMP inscriptions], dans les passages proches les uns des autres, employer une graphie qui rendait mieux la phonétique réelle. Ceci pourrait être encore un argument contre l’allongement spontané d’un -ǎ bref primaire” (Lecoq 2017: 221). We may add to Lecoq’s brilliant argument a couple of further considerations. We have demonstrated above that in PMP inscriptions spellings like <C> ~ <C-a> in final syllables likely hint at the loss of OP final nuclei and rhymes: <k-r-t-a> → /kart/, /a-p-d-a-n/ → /apadān/. These arguments are helpful in shedding light on decoding Lecoq’s /h-y/ spellings in Oblique.

Given the loss of /h/ and of final /ǎ/, the hypothetical spelling <C-h-y> (i.e. /Ca(h)y/) had to be necessarily read /Cē/: this spelling is *pour cause* the harbinger of <-y> forms in Sasanian pārsīk inscriptions. An /ē/ behind the <y> spelling in PMP is convincingly defended by Schmitt in the case of <p-r-d-y-d-a-m> in A²Sd^{a-d} 3, namely MP /pardēd/ “garden”.⁴⁶ Obviously, if we are quite certain that behind /-h-y/ there was the /ē/ of the Oblique, any other late /-h-y-a/ (where <a>, as usual, hints at an ancient *mater lectionis*), given the <C> = <C-a> equivalence in final syllables, could be traced back to an /ē/.

⁴⁶ See Schmitt 1999: 84; this interpretation was been subsequently accepted by Panaino 2012.

Philippe Huyse outlined the complex development that led to the retention of OP *-ahya* as **-ē* in early MP two-cases morphology, inasmuch as “il n’est pourtant pas improbable que, lors de ce processus, des désinences longues de plus d’une seule syllabe aient pu être partiellement ‘sauvées’ en moyen-perse, contrairement aux syllabes plus courtes” (Huyse 2003: 54). Huyse summarizes his own arguments as follows:

für den Ursprung dieser Endung kommt in erster Linie die eben genannte Endung des altpersischen Gen. Sg. Mask. der *-ā*- Stämme in Betracht (ap. *-āhāyā* > fmp. **-ē^h*; vgl. ausführlicher hierzu Huyse 2003, 53 f. und 95f.). Dieses frühmittelpersische **-ē^h* wird daraufhin weiter zu einem Nullmorphem ohne Lautwert reduziert; bis etwa zur Mitte des 2. Jh. s. n. Chr. verschwindet es demzufolge sogar ganz auf Schriftbild, bis es dann aus bisher ungeklärter Ursache plötzlich als pseudo-historisches Element in der Form eines Schluss-y auf den Münzenlegenden der Herrscher in der Persis wieder auftaucht. Die Schreibung des Schluss-y erfolgt nun nach den Regeln eines Rhythmusgesetzes. Dieses bleibt in etwa bis zum ausgehenden 5. Jh. n. Chr. in Kraft und wird danach schrittweise aufgegeben (Huyse 2005: 57-58).

Huyse formulated a “Rhythmusgesetz”, which extensively accounts for “Schluss-y” distribution in Sassanian Inscriptional MP. This “law” should depend on stress effects, showing that MP was a language sensitive to the heavy/light syllable distinction: a final bimoraic syllable (namely /ē/, written <y>) survived, if and only if it was preceded by a monomoraic stressed syllable; otherwise, it was dropped. According to Huyse’s reconstruction and to Henning’s view, the otiose <y> became the “final stroke” of Book Pahlavī cursive script; the paleographical process ended in the 7th century, when the purely graphic distributional law of the “final stroke”, discovered by Walter Belardi (Belardi 1986), is attested. However, Paolo Milizia, in a brief article, threw Huyse’s “rhythmic theory” in question, inasmuch as he prefers to take into account only graphic rules concerning the final <-y> distribution, since Huyse’s arguments seem circular:

il segno <-y> finale continua molto probabilmente una originaria desinenza di obliquo singolare *-ē* < **-ahya*; dopo la perdita di tale desinenza il corrispondente segmento grafico <-y>, poté sopravvivere come arcaismo nella scrittura di forme nominali, per essere presto rifunzionalizzato come segno di fine di parola. Nella nuova funzione di delimitatore <y> viene potenzialmente esteso all’intero lessico grafico di matrice iranica, sicché lo si trova non solo in forme nominali

singolari ma anche nomi al plurale e in forme verbali (Milizia 2011: 90-91).

Huysse’s tenets have been now defended by Ferrer-Losilla, who has recently made an intriguing attempt to explain the distribution of final <-y> “spelling convention” in inscriptional Parthian. Be that as it may, Ferrer-Losilla opines that “the occurrence of -y suggests a generalization of the ancient ending of the genitive singular, i.e., the case which expresses the agent in the past (ergative) constructions would have been used as the single case for the singular inflexion [sic] (also for the agentive constructions), at least for the thematic stems” (Ferrer-Losilla 2014: 66).

There is only one important exception adequately underlined by Rastorgueva & Molčanova and Sundermann,⁴⁷ where the “Schluss-y” does not go back to a purely graphic usage, and seems directly to reflect the outcome of an ancient Oblique form. In the inscriptions of Šāhpuhr in Hājjīābād, in Tang-e Borāq and in Veh- Šāhpuhr the spelling phrase <pwḥryphr> with the meaning of ‘grandson’, literally ‘son of the son’, recurs. Hence we can legitimately suppose that Parthian *puhrē puhr goes back to an Anc. Ir. *puθrahya puθra. To this Parthian example, Gert Klingenschmitt, in his *Mitelpersisch*, added a couple of interesting Book-Pahlavī fossils, which occur in *Dēnkart*: “nur bei einem seinem Beziehungswort vorausgestellten Genitiv attribute”, i.e. *gušnē(h) xṛītar* “male” and *dāmē daštār* “keeper of the creation” (Klingenschmitt 2000: 192 fn. 5).

11. In the light of the PMP linguistic data, which we systematically tried to read behind the “cuneiform masks” of the Late Achaemenid inscriptions, it is possible to draw some brief conclusions. Meillet’s “*entre-deux*”-problem, namely the “blackout” period from the OP monuments till to the Early MP documents, can be filled up with some interesting inferences from the cuneiform script of the non-formulaic sections in the Late Achaemenid texts. Thus, despite the overwhelming opinion of the scientific literature on this issue, these inscriptions are far from being “erroneous”, “barbaric” or “deviant”. On the contrary, they exhibit an *état de langue* that was coherently shifting to the MP stage. The morpho-syntactic framework concerning the diptotic noun inflection and the rise of the “ergative” construction in the analytical preterite can be easily detected. As far as the case-markers are concerned, a clear opposition between Sing.

⁴⁷ See Rastorgueva & Molčanova 1981: 188, Sundermann 1989a: 130.

Direct case with “zero-ending” vs Sing. Oblique case with *-ē* (without any asterisk) can be reliably reconstructed.

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